

5.2. System Requirements

The thing with using Sandbox tools is that the computer gets pushed into doing a lot of mathematical calculations at once, and this can slow down the process greatly on slower machines with little RAM and extinct chips. Lots and lots of RAM, an excellent video graphics card (which is updated for Vista—if you’re using Vista) and a hard disk that is not already filled, are some of the essential preconditions for a smooth and slick Sandbox experience.

Often the triangulation is so complex that if you want to “Add detail” or “Drape” over a TIN, the computer takes a long, long time to process the action—sometimes giving you the impression that it’s hung.

To simplify a terrain, download the Simplify Contours script from Downloads > Ruby Script at <http://www.sketchup.com/>, and restart SketchUp. You can then select the TIN you want to make simpler, click on the Plugins button in the menu above and click Simplify Contours.

Also, try to reduce the overall area of the terrain you’re working on (either by creating or selecting small portions of terrain), because endpoints of contours are more significant and will affect the performance of the Sandbox tools.

The system requirements for a trouble-free experience of the use of the Sandbox tools are the same as the requirements for the smooth functioning of SketchUp itself, as recommended below:

Hardware

- A 2-GHz Pentium 4 processor (or higher)
- 2 GB RAM (and you really thought 512 MB would be enough?)
- A Video card that is Open GL compliant (OpenGL is a method for rendering 3d images. GL stands for Graphics Language. OpenGL is the “open source” version of GL) with 512 MB Video memory, or one which is OpenGL 1.5+ compliant in case you’re working on a Mac.
- 15 GB of available hard disk space (160 MB for Macs)

You’re ready to enter the Sandbox now.